

Jin Yucheng (yucheng9)
Prof. Dana Rabin
History 100, Ethan's Section
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From Robespierre's Speech to See the "Reign of Terror" during the French Revolution

Today when somebody mentions the name of Maximilien Robespierre, many people may take it as a synonym of guillotine. As one of the most prominent historical figures during the French Revolution, Robespierre served as the leader of the country's executive authority, Committee of Public Safety. When this former lawyer was in office, radical revolutionaries launched the "Reign of Terror", during which thousands were executed in the name of "defending the Republic"¹. In his famous speech "On Political Morality" to the Convention, Robespierre explains his view towards democracy, and justifies his extensive uses of terror. However, from my perspective, although I agree with his idea that utilizing terror might be an effective approach to "lay the foundations of democracy"² during the turbulent years of political reorderings, I believe that terror is not the guardian of democracy, excessive terror and indiscriminate executions will ultimately lead to irreversible tragedies and leave indelible stains on the credibility of democracy.

At the beginning of his speech, Robespierre raises a question to his audience, "What is the goal toward which we are heading?". Shortly afterwards, he gives the answer by himself, "The peaceful enjoyment of liberty and equality"³. It is always easy to bring out this answer, but at that time when the newborn Republic had just went through wave after wave of wars against old-regime, it was extremely difficult to live out the creed of liberty and equality.

¹ Elizabeth Pollard, et al., eds., *Worlds Together, Worlds Apart: A History of the World From the Beginnings of Humankind to the Present*, Vol. 2, 3rd Edition (New York: W.W. Norton, 2019), 703.

² Maximilien Robespierre, "On Political Morality", in Elizabeth Pollard and Clifford Rosenberg, eds., *Worlds Together, Worlds Apart: A Companion Reader*, Vol. 2, 3rd Edition (New York: W.W. Norton, 2019), 181.

³ Maximilien Robespierre, "On Political Morality", 180.

After all, democracy was still fragile, and there were still considerable conservative forces, both internal and external, that rejected the political transformation, and were consistently trying to overthrow the young democratic government and bury the aspiration of Robespierre and other revolutionaries — just as Robespierre emphasizes, counter-revolutionary forces would never stop their effort “to kill public virtue, to stir up the fires of discord, and to prepare political counter-revolution by means of moral counter-revolution”⁴. To some extent, it was necessary for French revolutionaries to adopt some strong and tough measures to fight against the enemies of the Republic, as well as consolidate the immature democratic system they had newly established on the cost of enormous sacrifices. Therefore, as a weapon that armed the Republic, moderate use of terror was reasonable and even essential, without which democracy was fragile and impotent under the persistent attacks from conservative forces.

But unfortunately, as the French revolution became more and more radical, terror was no longer a guardian of the Republic, instead, with its despotic reign gradually swung into full gear, terror eventually devastated the advantages of the country’s democratic system.

According to historical records, as many as 40,000 French citizens were executed by the Committee of Public Safety, however, ironically, most of them were peasants and laborers⁵, who could have been the most faithful and dedicated allies of the revolutionaries. Even though Robespierre asserts with confidence that “Terror is nothing but prompt, severe, inflexible justice; it is therefore an emanation of virtue”⁶, in reality, no one could deny that “justice” was rapidly becoming suffocating oppression, and “virtue” was furiously transforming into intolerant dogma. As more and more innocent civilians were framed,

⁴ Maximilien Robespierre, “On Political Morality”, 183.

⁵ Elizabeth Pollard, et al., eds., *Worlds Together, Worlds Apart: A History of the World From the Beginnings of Humankind to the Present*, Vol. 2, 3rd Edition (New York: W.W. Norton, 2019), 703.

⁶ Maximilien Robespierre, “On Political Morality”, 183.

arrested, sentenced, and even executed, unappeasable anger was also silently accumulating among the people. Finally, Robespierre himself went to the guillotine after the Thermidorian Reaction, marking the end of the “Reign of Terror”. If we look back into history, it was satirical that to some extent, Robespierre somehow successfully predicted his downfall and death. As he says in his speech, “we must finish the war of liberty against tyranny and safely cross through the storms of the revolution”⁷, the war of liberty against the tyranny of terror was exactly finished by the execution of Robespierre, then his successor, Napoleon Bonaparte, the young but ambitious lion from Corsica, led French steadily cross through the turbulent years of revolution.

In conclusion, terror is a double-edged sword, it not only can serve as a warrior that fights for democracy, but also can become a tyrant who will eventually ruin the achievements of numerous dauntless revolutionaries. During the transitional period when a new political system is established, terror may exert its advantage of resisting the counterattacks from conservative forces. However, if terror becomes excessive and indiscriminate, its reign can not only be anti-democracy, but may be even worse than absolutism and dictatorship. Therefore, in my opinion, as today’s citizens, we must realize the danger of potential “Reign of Terror”, and build our country with real liberty and freedom based on the foundation of solid logos and rational legality.

⁷ Maximilien Robespierre, “On Political Morality”, 181.